Connect the Dots

written by:

Connor Wray



INT. OFFICE - NIGHT

Open black. Title card. Noir jazz plays.

Match strikes and lights cigarette. GUNNIE turns on a lamp revealing a wildly convoluted conspiracy board.

Gunnie sits in front of the board, admiring it.

GUNNIE
(internal dialogue)
Ok. So what do we know?

CLOSEUP ON PICTURE OF A SMILING YOUNG WOMAN ON THE BOARD. BILLIE.

GUNNIE
(cont'd)
Victim: Billie Jean. No relation.
Cause of death:

STILL SHOT ON RIVER.

GUNNIE
(cont'd)
Drowning. Pulled from the Eastern river on Friday. Details not yet public. Her best friend: Laurie White,

CLOSEUP ON PICTURE OF LAURIE ON THE BOARD.

GUNNIE
(cont'd)
Suspects foul play.

INT. RESTAURANT - DAY

CLOSEUP OF LAURIE FROM ACROSS THE TABLE.

LAURIE
She hated swimming. She loved boating but hated swimming. She didn't like getting her hair wet. If she fell off the boat and had to swim, she would, but I checked the weather for the day she passed: clear skies. Nothing. I think she was held under water. I think she was murdered.

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INT. OFFICE - NIGHT

Gunnie scans the board.

GUNNIE
(inner dialogue)
Everything checks out. Surprisingly helpful. A good lead. As for suspects:

We cut between various overlapping shots of characters/suspects being interrogated:

THE BOYFRIEND
(in tears)
Jeanie...was...so...special.

CUT TO:

ROOMMATE
Social.

UNCLE
Funny lookin.

NEIGHBOR
Loud.

EX-BEST-FRIEND
A fucking liar.

MOM
Just misunderstood.

SISTER
Sweet.

EX-BOYFRIEND
A whore.

DOG
(barks)

BOSS
Late for everything.

CHILDHOOD FRIEND
Really self absorbed.

BROTHER
I don't know, I guess she was cool.

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COUSIN
Very very very oblivious.

CUT BACK TO GUNNIE LOOKING AT THE WALL OF SUSPECTS:

GUNNIE
(cont'd)
It's tough to narrow it down.

Starting with the "ex's", clearest motive:

Her ex-best-friend, Kelly, lives out of state and seems to be living a good life. Obviously still has some resentment, something about a high school love triangle, but doesn't seem like a killer.

Ex-boyfriend, Derek, also not her biggest fan. Kind of obsessive, but:

EXT. CAFE - DAY

Ex-boyfriend is sitting across from Gunnie at a cafe outdoors.

EX-BOYFRIEND
(holding back tears)
She fucking cheated on me man, do you know how much that fucks someone up? Fuckin bullshit. With Chad?! Fucking CHAD? How do you cheat on "Derek" with a guy named "Chad"!? It was messy, and I had a problem after things ended. Checking her social media, checking her stories, texting her I missed her and shit. But then I started going to therapy, journaling, working through my frustrations. I learned it's ok to have that resentment as long as I don't let it consume me. And I don't. I'm don't think she's a good person but I don't think she deserved to die. I wouldn't kill her, man.

INT. OFFICE - NIGHT

GUNNIE
(cont'd)
He seems sincere. Next, the roommate

was at work at the time of death. The neighbor doesn't have much motivation and was at the apartment at the time of death.

Which leaves the family.

FOCUS ON SIX PICTURES CONNECTED ON THE CONSPIRACY BOARD:

MOM, BROTHER, SISTER, COUSIN, UNCLE, AND BILLIE.

GUNNIE
Shit, Billie, that's a bad way to go...

Gunnie approaches the board with a marker in hand. Gunnie opens a notebook and looks through his interrogations.

INT. LIVING ROOM - DAY

The Mom is dabbing away tears at the table.

GUNNIE
(v.o.)
First, the mom.

MOM
She was a rebel. She didn't like listening to what I had to say, or what anyone had to say for that matter. She would just do what she wanted. I tried, I really did to keep her out of trouble, but it just pushed her further away. She was difficult but I loved my daughter.

INT. KITCHEN - DAY

Sister is cooking food in her kitchen.

GUNNIE
(v.o.)
The sister.

SISTER
We didn't get along. I tried to be close with her but she just wouldn't meet me halfway. I just keep thinking back to the day she died. We got into a big fight, we both started yelling, we both said things we probably

shouldn't have, and then she stormed off to go home. I don't even know how she ended up in the Eastern River, it's not on the way to her house. She'd have to take a weird back road to pass by it.

INT. BEDROOM - DAY

Brother is playing Dark Souls and losing.

GUNNIE
(v.o.)
The brother.

BROTHER
I think she visited a few times this week but I didn't really see her. She just kind of hung out and talked with mom for an hour before leaving. Didn't sound like anything serious though.

INT. LIVING ROOM - DAY

Uncle is in a jersey for a football watch party. Several friends are standing around the tv, Uncle holds a beer firmly in hand.

GUNNIE
(v.o.)
The uncle.

UNCLE
She called sometimes to ask for money or help moving around furniture. Sweet kid, loved coming with me to the field to watch the games. She texted me something about her sister being a "cunt" but that was all I got from her the day she died. I've been checking up on her mom since it happened, obviously, but she seems to be doing fine. I'm gonna miss that kid. Real tragedy.

Touchdown on tv.

UNCLE
(cont'd)
LETS GO!

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EXT. PATIO - DAY

Cousin is drinking wine and scrolling on her iPad.

GUNNIE
(v.o.)
And the cousin.

COUSIN
We were closer as kids but over time she just started changing too much. She had so much promise and then she just kind of threw it away to act like a child and party. It was disappointing but I wasn't about to let that affect me. I feel bad for her more than anything. I wish she was still around. I feel like if she was, she might have moved out of whatever phase she was in. Maybe she would've found herself again.

INT. OFFICE - NIGHT

Pull away from the photos of the family. Gunnie is stumped. He opens up a file and looks over key notes from the case:

Drowned.

Killed Thursday.

Found Friday.

Eastern River.

Signs of struggle.

To be announced on Tuesday.

Gunnie looks up, something connects. He looks between the conspiracy board and the file.

FLASHBACKS:

GUNNIE
Drowning. Pulled from the Eastern river -

SISTER
(overlapping)
Eastern river. It's not on the way to

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her house.

GUNNIE
(cont'd)
-found on Friday.

SISTER
We got into a big fight. We both said things...

GUNNIE
Details not yet public.

SISTER
(cont'd)
...we probably shouldn't have.

FLASHBACK ENDS.

Gunnie looks through his notes for the sister. Motive checks out, no alibi, and had information before it was released.

GUNNIE
Of course you know. You did it, didn't you?

Closeup on the sisters photo on the conspiracy board. Gunnie moves away from the board and grabs his coat. He starts for the door and when he opens it, standing in the doorway is: the sister.

In her hand is a gun.

Beat.

GUNNIE
I was just looking for you.

The sister doesn't hesitate - she tries to shoot and misses. They fight. As they brawl, the sister manages to grab hold of several items to try and improvise killing Gunnie:

A candlestick, some rope, a wrench, a lead pipe, and a letter opener. After some wrestling, Gunnie has the sister pinned down and her wrists zip-tied. Both of them are beat up.

GUNNIE
You're under arrest for the murder of-

SISTER
You're not a cop!

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GUNNIE
Sorry.

EXT. APARTMENTS - NIGHT

Red and blue lights flash against Gunnie's face as cops escort the sister into a police car. A job well done.

The sister glares at Gunnie through the window. Gunnie just nods.

Police cars drive away and more noir jazz plays as we pull away from Gunnie - he gets up and walks back inside.

THE END.

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